When India celebrated its 78th anniversary of Independence this August 15, the country stood on the cusp of a transformative economic decade. One that will be shaped not just by sprawling industrial conglomerates or billion-dollar unicorns, but by the quiet and consistent rise of India's unsung entrepreneurs who work on looms, toil in two-room factories, commute mostly on two-wheelers and come home to load-shedding. They convert local problems and needs into entrepreneurial opportunities and create millions of jobs while sustaining India's social and economic fabric. In size, these micromoguls may be modest, but their impact on the economy is colossal and their life stories are truly inspiring.

Take Rupankar Bhattacharjee, who was bitten by the entrepreneurial bug in the most unusual of circumstances. A wildlife enthusiast, he was on a quest to track an elusive python when it disappeared into the dense thicket of water hyacinth that carpeted Assam's Deepor Beel, a vast freshwater lake, near Guwahati. That moment turned his mind towards the invasive weed—how much it had choked the state's wetlands, turning sprawling zones of aquatic biodiversity into watery graveyards. Rupankar got thinking about how to get rid of it and, along with his friend Aniket Dhar, researched and found that the hyacinth's high fibre content was perfect for paper production.

Thus was born Kumbhi Kagaz in 2022. After securing Rs 8.3 lakh from Waste Aid, a UK-based charity promoting waste management, the duo set up a factory on the outskirts of Guwahati. They developed a custom-designed machine to convert the hyacinth into paper. Soon, their catchment expanded to the wetlands of the Kaziranga National Park after a grant from Assam Startup, a central government initiative that encourages such ventures. Their turnover has begun to show a profit, and national recognition came recently when Prime Minister Narendra Modi mentioned their success in *Mann Ki Baat*, his monthly radio broadcast.

Some 2,300 km away in Aurangabad, there is Sandeep Dabhade, who was initially keen on being a tabla player and was eking out a living by performing across Maharashtra. "There were days when getting even two meals was a luxury," he recalls. To make ends meet, he joined a packaging company, where he excelled as an all-rounder, handling operations, marketing and accounts. That's when he decided to go solo, investing his savings and mortgaging his family gold to set up EcoPack in 2019 and begin trading in packaging materials. COVID laid low his business the very next year, but help came in the form of a working capital loan of Rs 11 lakh from a non-profit trust. The post-pandemic phase saw his business boom, and a Hindustan Unilever supplier became a major client. With that success, he started a new venture—processing sugarcane into chemical-free jaggery on his farm. Now, he is encouraging other farmers to do so too, hoping to make his hometown Jalna an agri-processing hub.

Meanwhile, in the pristine forests of Jashpur in northern Chhattisgarh, an initiative by former district magistrate Ravi Mittal brought together a group of tribals to turn the abundant forest produce into a range of organic products. That initiative came to be called the Jai Jungle Farmer Producer Company, its mandate being to help women's self-help groups (SHG) brand and market their wares under the label Jashpure. Among the many products are those made out of the mahua tree, found in abundance in the region. Its many medicinal values are extracted without using chemicals, additives or adulterants. These include the nectar from the mahua flower, which serves as an alternative to honey. The company now has an annual turnover of Rs 60 lakh, putting money into women's hands and empowering them with a rare economic independence.

> **"The Centre's MSME policies are directed towards making these enterprises grow in size so that they enjoy the benefits of economies of scale and ensure the requisite quality critical to make inroads into global value chains"**
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> **P.K. MISHRA,** *Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister*

VITAL LIFELINE

With over 66 million micro units across the country, entrepreneurs operating on this scale straddle 99 per cent of the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) sector. MSMEs now employ 244 million people, or nearly 43 per cent of India's 565 million-strong